

Chapter 25 — "Spot the Niphal" Passage Exercise

Genesis 3, 6, and 21 · The Garden, the Flood Prelude, and Beersheba

Most highlighted verbs are Niphal forms. For each one, first answer Is it Niphal? (Yes / No). If Yes: parse conjugation, PGN, and root, then state the semantic function (Passive / Reflexive / Middle / Simple Action). If No: identify the correct stem and parse fully. Three verbs in this exercise are not Niphal — drawn from Qal already studied. Answer key begins on the page marked "Answer Key".

Passage A — Genesis 3:5–10

3:5

וְהָיִיתֶם כְּאֱלֹהִים יֹדְעֵי טוֹב וָרָע כִּי יָדַע אֱלֹהִים כִּי בַיּוֹם אָכַלְתֶּם מִמֶּנּוּ וּנְפַקְחוּ עֵינֵיכֶם

"...for God knows that in the day you eat of it your eyes will [1] ____."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
1	וּנְפַקְחוּ				

3:6

וַתֵּרָא הָאִשָּׁה כִּי טוֹב הָעֵץ ... וַנְּחַמֵּד הָעֵץ לְהַשְׁכִּיל

"So when the woman [2] ____ that the tree was good ... and the tree was [3] ____ to make one wise."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
2	וַתֵּרָא				
3	וַנְּחַמֵּד				

3:7

וַתִּפְקְחוּהָ עֵינֵי שְׁנֵיהֶם

"Then the eyes of both of them [4] ____."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
4	וַתִּפְקְחוּהָ				

3:10

וַאֲרָא כִּי־עֵרָם אֲנִי וְאֶחָבָא

"I was afraid, because I was naked, and [5] ____."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
5	וְאֶחָבָא				

Passage B — Genesis 6:6–12

6:6

וַיִּנָּחַם יְהוָה כִּי־עָשָׂה אֶת־הָאָדָם בָּאָרֶץ

"And the LORD [6] ____ that he [7] ____ man on the earth."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
6	וַיִּנְחֶם				
7	עָשָׂה				

6:7

נִחַמְתִּי כִּי עָשִׂיתֶם

"I [8] ____ that I made them."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
8	נִחַמְתִּי				

6:11

וַתִּשְׁחַת הָאָרֶץ ... וַתִּמְלֵא הָאָרֶץ חָמָס

"The earth [9] ____ ... and the earth [10] ____ with violence."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
9	וַתִּשְׁחַת				
10	וַתִּמְלֵא				

6:12

וְהִנֵּה נִשְׁחָתָה כִּי־הִשְׁחִית כָּל־בָּשָׂר

"and behold, it [11] ____, for all flesh had corrupted its way."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
11	נִשְׁחָתָה				

6:21

וְהָיָה לָּךְ וּלְהֶם לְאֹכֶלָּה יֵאָכֵל

"it shall be food for you and for them — it shall [12] ____."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
12	יֵאָכֵל				

Passage C — Genesis 21:23–31

21:23

הַשְּׂבָעָה לִּי בְּאֵלֵהֶם הִנֵּה

"[13] ____ to me by God here."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
13	הַשְּׂבָעָה				

21:24

וַיֹּאמֶר אַבְרָהָם אֲנֹכִי אֲשָׁבַע

"And Abraham said, 'I [14] ____.'"

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
14	אָשַׁבַּע				

21:31

כִּי שָׁם נִשְׁבַּעַן שְׁנֵיהֶם

"For there [15] ____ both of them."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
15	נִשְׁבַּעַן				

Bonus — Genesis 21:3, 21:8

21:3

אֲשֶׁר-נִוְלַד-לּוֹ

"who had been born to him"

21:8

וַיִּגְדֵּל הַיֶּלֶד וַיִּגְמַל

"And the child [16] ____ and was weaned."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
B1	נִוְלַד				
16	וַיִּגְדֵּל				
B2	וַיִּגְמַל				

Items 6–8 (אָשַׁבַּע / אֲשַׁבְּעָנִי) are both from אָשַׁבַּע, a verb that occurs almost exclusively in the Niphal. Items 13–15 all parse as Reflexive from שָׁבַע — notice how Imperative, Imperfect, and Weqatal all express the same oath-swearing action.

Score: 13 Niphal + 3 non-Niphal + 2 bonus = 18 total. 15–18 = excellent | 11–14 = review the paradigm | below 11 = revisit §23.3

Conjugation Coverage

Conjugation	Verbs
Wayyiqtol (6)	#4, #5, #6, #9, #10, B2
Weqatal (5)	#1, #8, #11, #15, B1
Imperfect (2)	#12, #14
Participle (1)	#3
Imperative (1)	#13
Non-Niphal (3)	#2 (Qal Wayyiqtol 3fs), #7 (Qal Perfect 3ms), #16 (Qal Wayyiqtol 3ms)

Reflection Questions

- Every Niphal in Passage A (Gen 3) involves eyes, hiding, or desire. What does the Niphal contribute to the theological message of the Fall narrative?
- In Gen 6:6–7, God is the subject of a Niphal-only verb (אָשַׁבַּע). What does this choice tell us about how the narrator portrays God's emotional response?

3. Compare Gen 3:5 (יִפְתָּח — "will be opened," Middle/Tolerative) with Gen 3:7 (נִפְתְּחוּ — "were opened," Middle). Is the function identical in both? What difference in nuance, if any, does the shift from weqatal to wayyiqtol suggest?

Answer Key

Passages with correct answers shown in the green row below each verb.

Passage A — Genesis 3:5–10

3:5

וַהֲיִיתֶם כְּאֱלֹהִים יְדַעְתִּי טוֹב וְרָע כִּי יָדַע אֱלֹהִים כִּי בַיּוֹם אֲכַלְתֶּם מִמֶּנּוּ וּנְפַקְחוּ עֵינֵיכֶם

"...for God knows that in the day you eat of it your eyes will [1] ____."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
1	וּנְפַקְחוּ				see ↓
✓	וּנְפַקְחוּ	Weqatal	3cp	פָּקַח	Middle — will be opened

3:6

וַתֵּרָא הָאִשָּׁה כִּי טוֹב הָעֵץ ... וַנְּחַמֵּד הָעֵץ לְהַשְׁכִּיל

"So when the woman [2] ____ that the tree was good ... and the tree was [3] ____ to make one wise."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
2	וַתֵּרָא				see ↓
✓	וַתֵּרָא	Wayyiqtol	3fs	רָאָה	NOT Niphal — Qal: and she saw; III-■
3	וַנְּחַמֵּד				see ↓
✓	וַנְּחַמֵּד	Participle ms	ms	חָמַד	Passive — desirable (substantival ptc.)

3:7

וַתִּפְקְחוּהָ עֵינֵי שְׁנֵיהֶם

"Then the eyes of both of them [4] ____."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
4	וַתִּפְקְחוּהָ				see ↓
✓	וַתִּפְקְחוּהָ	Wayyiqtol	3fp	פָּקַח	Middle — they were opened

3:10

וַאֲרָא כִּי־עֵרָם אָנֹכִי וְאֶחָבָא

"I was afraid, because I was naked, and [5] ____."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
5	וְאֶחָבָא				see ↓
✓	וְאֶחָבָא	Wayyiqtol	1cs	חָבָא	Reflexive — I hid myself

Passage B — Genesis 6:6–12

6:6

וַיִּנָּחַם יְהוָה כִּי־עָשָׂה אֶת־הָאָדָם בָּאָרֶץ

"And the LORD [6] ____ that he [7] ____ man on the earth."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
6	וַיִּנָּחֵם				see ↓
✓	וַיִּנָּחֵם	Wayyiqtol	3ms	נָחַם	Simple Action (Niphal-only) — relented
7	עָשָׂה				see ↓
✓	עָשָׂה	Perfect	3ms	עָשָׂה	NOT Niphal — Qal: he made/did; III-■

6:7

נִחַמְתִּי כִּי עָשִׂיתֶם

"I [8] ____ that I made them."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
8	נִחַמְתִּי				see ↓
✓	נִחַמְתִּי	Weqatal	1cs	נָחַם	Simple Action (Niphal-only) — I regret

6:11

וַתִּשְׁחַת הָאָרֶץ ... וַתִּמְלֵא הָאָרֶץ חֲמָס

"The earth [9] ____ ... and the earth [10] ____ with violence."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
9	וַתִּשְׁחַת				see ↓
✓	וַתִּשְׁחַת	Wayyiqtol	3fs	שָׁחַת	Passive — it was corrupted
10	וַתִּמְלֵא				see ↓
✓	וַתִּמְלֵא	Wayyiqtol	3fs	מָלָא	Passive — it was filled

6:12

וַהֲבֵינָה נִשְׁחָתָה כִּי־הִשְׁחִית כָּל־בָּשָׂר

"and behold, it [11] ____, for all flesh had corrupted its way."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
11	נִשְׁחָתָה				see ↓
✓	נִשְׁחָתָה	Weqatal	3fs	שָׁחַת	Passive — it was corrupt

6:21

וְהָיָה לָרֶגֶל וּלְהֶם לְאֹכֶלָה יֵאָכֵל

"it shall be food for you and for them — it shall [12] ____."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
12	יֵאָכֵל				see ↓
✓	יֵאָכֵל	Imperfect	3ms	אָכַל	Passive — it shall be eaten

Passage C — Genesis 21:23–31

21:23

הַשְׁבַּעָה לִי בְּאֵלֵהֶם הִנֵּה

"[13] ____ to me by God here."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
13	הַשְׁבַּעָה				see ↓
✓	הַשְׁבַּעָה	Imperative	2ms	שָׁבַע	Reflexive — Swear! (bind yourself by

21:24

וַיֹּאמֶר אַבְרָהָם אֲנֹכִי אֶשְׁבַּע

"And Abraham said, 'I [14] ____.'"

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
14	אֶשְׁבַּע				see ↓
✓	אֶשְׁבַּע	Imperfect	1cs	שָׁבַע	Reflexive — I will swear

21:31

כִּי שָׁם נִשְׁבָּעוּ שְׁנֵיהֶם

"For there [15] ____ both of them."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
15	נִשְׁבָּעוּ				see ↓
✓	נִשְׁבָּעוּ	Weqatal	3mp	שָׁבַע	Reflexive — they swore (bound

Bonus — Genesis 21:3, 21:8

21:3

אֲשֶׁר-נִוְלַד-לּוֹ

"who had been born to him"

21:8

וַיִּגְדֵּל הַיֶּלֶד וַיִּגְמַל

"And the child [16] ____ and was weaned."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
B1	נִוְלַד				see ↓
✓	נִוְלַד	Weqatal	3ms	וָלַד	Passive — who had been born
16	וַיִּגְדֵּל				see ↓
✓	וַיִּגְדֵּל	Wayyiqtol	3ms	גָּדַל	NOT Niphal — Qal: and he grew; plain
B2	וַיִּגְמַל				see ↓
✓	וַיִּגְמַל	Wayyiqtol	3ms	גָּמַל	Passive — was weaned

Items 6–8 (יָתַחְתִּי / יָתַחְתִּי) are both from יָתַח, a verb that occurs almost exclusively in the Niphal. Items 13–15 all parse as Reflexive from שָׁעַבְתִּי — notice how Imperative, Imperfect, and Weqatal all express the same oath-swearing action.

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